

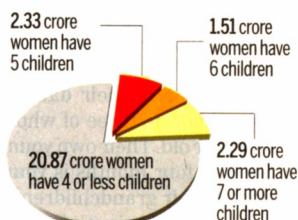
Many Children NO ISSUE

Many of India's poor do not think that having big and growing families is a bad idea

Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR/www.indiatodayimages.com

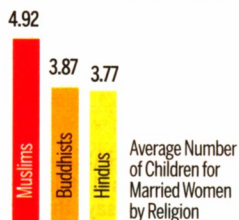


MOTHERS WITH BIG FAMILIES



Total Number of Married Women is 27 crore

GOD'S OWN CHILDREN



Source: Census 2001

By Rohit Parihar

When Sharda, 35, a resident of village Aanwa in Rajasthan's Tonk district gave birth to her 12th child, a daughter, in October last year, she named her Sania. It's not a distinction the Indian tennis star, who she was named after, will endorse. Sharda and her husband Prem Chand Kanjar, a driver, have three sons and nine daughters. They also have four grandchildren, all elder to their newborn daughter. "What is your problem when we are happy with so many kids?" says Sharda when asked why

BHANWAR LAL GUJJAR, 40, AND WIFE MANA, 35, WORK ON A NREGA PROJECT

The couple already have 11 children and Mana is expecting her 12th. They have four grandchildren, all of who are elder to their youngest child.

she does not ask her husband to stop expanding the family. Even as the urban trend in India of couples opting for just one child becomes old news, there is another India where men and women are procreating unhindered. It is a serious social and economic issue since there are literally crores of women with more than half-a-dozen children, thus negating the impact of couples who opt for two or just one.

Census 2001 revealed that out of

27 crore married women, 2.3 crore had more than seven children, equal to those with five children. In fact, 22 per cent of women of all ages have more than five children. In terms of numbers, it's a frightening figure: more than 6.13 crore women have five or more children. A simple calculation would mean that nearly 1.25 crore children have been added to families who already had six children since the 2001 Census. Most of these are from